

97 Manasseh

Judah's most wicked king, who was humbled in chains and found that God still hears.

Manasseh was the son of good King Hezekiah, but he undid almost everything his father had done. He became king at twelve and reigned fifty-five years, longer than any other king of Judah. He set up altars to Baal and the stars inside the temple, practised sorcery, made his children pass through the fire, and filled Jerusalem with innocent blood. Kings says his sins sealed Judah's fate. Yet Chronicles adds a surprising turn. Taken to Babylon in chains by the Assyrians, Manasseh humbled himself and prayed, and God brought him home. He spent his last years trying to repair the damage.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Menashsheh</i> , "causing to forget" (Genesis 41:51)
Family	Son of Hezekiah and Hephzibah; father of Amon (2 Kings 21:1, 18)
Reign	55 years from age 12, c. 697–642 BC, probably first with his father
Key places	Jerusalem, the temple, the valley of Hinnom, Babylon
Key people	Hezekiah, Amon, the prophets, the king of Assyria
Main passages	2 Kings 21:1–18; 2 Chronicles 33:1–20
New Testament	Named as "Manasses" in Matthew 1:10

"And prayed unto him: and he was intreated of him, and heard his supplication, and brought him again to Jerusalem into his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the LORD he was God."

2 Chronicles 33:13, KJV

The life of Manasseh

Dates are approximate (BC). Many scholars think Manasseh reigned with his father from c. 697 BC and alone from c. 686 BC. Scripture does not say when he was taken to Babylon.

c. 697 BC Age 12	● Becomes king Manasseh begins his reign of fifty-five years in Jerusalem. <i>2 Kings 21:1; 2 Chronicles 33:1</i>
c. 686 BC Sole king	● Undoes his father's reforms He rebuilds the high places, raises altars to Baal, makes an Asherah pole, and worships the stars, even in the temple courts. <i>2 Kings 21:2-7; 2 Chronicles 33:2-7</i>
During his reign	● Deaf to the prophets The LORD warns through his prophets that he will wipe Jerusalem "as a man wipeth a dish." Manasseh and his people will not listen. <i>2 Kings 21:10-15; 2 Chronicles 33:10</i>
During his reign	● Innocent blood He sheds so much innocent blood that Jerusalem is filled with it from one end to the other. <i>2 Kings 21:16</i>
Date unknown	● Captive and humbled The captains of the king of Assyria bind him with fetters and carry him to Babylon. In distress he humbles himself and prays, and God restores him to Jerusalem. <i>2 Chronicles 33:11-13</i>
After his return	● Repairs the damage He removes the foreign gods from the temple, restores the LORD's altar, and commands Judah to serve the LORD. He also strengthens Jerusalem's walls. <i>2 Chronicles 33:14-17</i>
c. 642 BC Age 67	● Dies He is buried in the garden of his own house, and his son Amon reigns. <i>2 Kings 21:18; 2 Chronicles 33:20</i>

Key activities

Kings does not mention Manasseh's repentance. It stresses that his sins were so great that judgment on Judah could not be turned back (2 *Kings* 23:26; 24:3–4). *Chronicles* adds his captivity and prayer. The two accounts stand side by side.

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- 1 Rebuilt what his father tore down.** He restored the high places Hezekiah had destroyed. *2 Kings 21:3*

 - 2 Defiled the temple.** He built altars for the host of heaven in both temple courts and set a carved idol in the house of God. *2 Kings 21:4–7; 2 Chronicles 33:4–7*

 - 3 Gave his children to the fire.** He made his children pass through the fire in the valley of the son of Hinnom and turned to witchcraft and mediums. *2 Kings 21:6; 2 Chronicles 33:6*

 - 4 Led Judah astray.** He led the people to do more evil than the nations God had driven out. *2 Kings 21:9; 2 Chronicles 33:9*

 - 5 Shed innocent blood.** He "shed innocent blood very much, till he had filled Jerusalem from one end to another." *2 Kings 21:16*

 - 6 Humbled himself in chains.** In Babylon he "besought the LORD his God, and humbled himself greatly." *2 Chronicles 33:11–12*

 - 7 Knew the LORD was God.** God heard him and brought him home, and he learned who God really was. *2 Chronicles 33:13*

 - 8 Tried to undo the harm.** He removed the idols, restored true worship, and built up Jerusalem's defences. The people still sacrificed at the high places, though now to the LORD. *2 Chronicles 33:14–17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Manasseh.

Old Testament

2 Kings 21:1–18; 2 Chronicles 33:1–20	The two accounts of his reign
2 Kings 23:26; 24:3–4	Judah's fall traced to his sins and innocent blood
Jeremiah 15:4	Exile "because of Manasseh the son of Hezekiah"
2 Chronicles 33:18–19	His prayer recorded among the kings and seers
Echo: 1 Kings 21:27–29	Ahab humbled himself, and judgment was delayed
Echo: Isaiah 1:18	Sins as scarlet made "white as snow"

New Testament

Matthew 1:10	"Manasses" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: Luke 15:17–24	The prodigal comes to himself and goes home
Echo: 1 Timothy 1:15–16	The chief of sinners, shown mercy as a pattern

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What happened to Manasseh in Babylon, and what did he do there (2 Chronicles 33:11–13)?
2. *Understand:* Manasseh was forgiven, yet the harm he did lived on after him. How do both of those things fit together?
3. *Apply:* Is there anyone you think is too far gone for God? How does Manasseh's story challenge that?
4. *Apply:* Manasseh tried to repair what he had broken. Is there something you need to put right, and what is the first step?